who advocated compliance with international institutions' demands. These leaders positioned themselves as defenders of national dignity against external economic dictates, leveraging public discontent to consolidate their political platforms and often implementing anti-democratic reforms in the process (see Meyerrose 2020).

On the donor side, populist-led states often harbor a deep-seated aversion to foreign aid and the financial contributions mandated by IFIs. For example, Trump's administration voiced repeated grievances over the substantial financial commitments required by NATO and various UN bodies, reflecting a broader, populist skepticism of multilateral institutions that demand significant fiscal outflows. Trump was especially averse to the World Bank's lending to middle-income countries like China and India, culminating in the appointment of David Malpass as president of the institution.

This resistance to IFIs manifests not only in financial reluctance but also in the withholding of critical information. For IFIs, data are a vital currency—they rely on accurate and timely information to craft expert recommendations and policy prescriptions. As we explore statistically in chapter 3, populist leaders are often hesitant to share such information, and this reticence can undermine the institutions' ability to function effectively.

In some cases, populist frustration drives the creation of alternative institutions that better align with their preferences and impose fewer demands on their members (Pratt 2021). These competitor organizations allow populist leaders to reduce their reliance on traditional IFIs or, in extreme cases, to withdraw entirely (von Borzyskowski and Vabulas 2019b). This exit option is particularly feasible in the development area, given the proliferation of organizations operating in this space (Lipscy 2015).

Ultimately, both populist-led donor and recipient states have strong incentives to distance themselves from IFIs. For donors, the financial burdens and perceived inefficiencies of these institutions fuel opposition, while recipients reject the sovereignty constraints and technocratic influence associated with IFI engagement. Together, these dynamics threaten to erode the effectiveness and legitimacy of IFIs, posing significant challenges to their operations and their broader role in global governance.